

# Children First Safeguarding and Child Protection Policy (covers Mandated Person Procedure, DLP role, Allegations Against Staff)

SECTIONS 1-4: PURPOSE, SCOPE, RESPONSIBILITIES & SAFEGUARDING PROCEDURES

## 1 PURPOSE

To ensure the safety, protection and wellbeing of all children and young people in our care in accordance with Children First: National Guidance for the Protection and Welfare of Children (2017), Tusla requirements, HIQA National Standards for Children's Residential Centres and the Child Care Act 1991.

## 2 SCOPE

- ✓ All staff, volunteers and contractors working with children and young people
- ✓ All aspects of identification, reporting, management and prevention of abuse and harm
- ✓ Children First Mandated Persons, Designated Liaison Person (DLP) and allegations procedures
- ✓ All placements, activities, online and off-site settings

## 3 RESPONSIBILITIES

- ✓ **Provider & PIC:** Ensure resources, training and oversight of the DLP system
- ✓ **Care Staff & Key Workers:** Observe, listen to the child, record concerns and report immediately
- ✓ **Designated Liaison Person (DLP):** Receive reports, liaise with Tusla, maintain records
- ✓ **All Mandated Persons:** Complete Children First eLearning and report concerns as legally required
- ✓ **All Staff:** Promote a culture of openness, complete vetting and annual safeguarding refresher training

## 4 SAFEGUARDING PROCEDURES

- ✓ Clear step-by-step reporting pathway for any child protection concern displayed prominently
- ✓ Immediate verbal report to DLP followed by written record on the same day
- ✓ Safe recruitment, Garda vetting and reference checks for all staff and volunteers
- ✓ Regular review of risk assessments for each young person
- ✓ Allegations against staff managed in line with Tusla and employer procedures with immediate protective actions

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SECTIONS 5-7: CHILD INVOLVEMENT, SPECIFIC RISKS & ALLEGATIONS MANAGEMENT

## 5 CHILD & FAMILY INVOLVEMENT



- ✓ Children and young people encouraged to raise concerns safely and know who to tell
- ✓ Family members informed of safeguarding arrangements on placement
- ✓ Views of the child central to all decisions and recorded
- ✓ Independent advocacy and complaints routes explained and accessible
- ✓ Feedback from children reviewed quarterly by management

## 6 SPECIFIC RISKS

- ✓ Child Sexual Exploitation and Criminal Exploitation procedures included
- ✓ Self-harm and suicide risk assessment tools and response protocols documented
- ✓ Substance misuse and online grooming risks addressed in individual plans
- ✓ All concerns documented in care plans and shared safely with relevant agencies
- ✓ Staff trained in trauma-informed and culturally sensitive practice

## 7 ALLEGATIONS AGAINST STAFF

- ✓ Immediate suspension or reassignment pending investigation when required
- ✓ Mandatory notification to Tusla, An Garda Síochána and the Registered Provider
- ✓ Support provided to the child, staff member and team
- ✓ Full investigation conducted in line with Children First and internal policy
- ✓ Lessons learned incorporated into training and policy review



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SECTIONS 8-10: COMPLIANCE, MONITORING & POLICY REVIEW

## 8 COMPLIANCE & TRAINING

- ✓ All staff complete Children First training and annual refreshers
- ✓ Mandatory reporting obligations clearly displayed and understood
- ✓ Records maintained securely in line with GDPR and Tusla guidance
- ✓ Regular internal audits of safeguarding files
- ✓ Immediate action taken on any suspected breach or near miss

## 9 MONITORING & REVIEW

- ✓ Regular audits of safeguarding records, training logs and incident reports and protected in present reports
- ✓ Regular audits of safeguarding records, training logs and incident reports
- ✓ Feedback from children, families and staff on safety and trust
- ✓ All incidents and near misses reported and analysed
- ✓ Compliance with individual placement plans and risk assessments reviewed monthly
- ✓ Ongoing competency checks and supervision of the DLP role

## 10 POLICY REVIEW

- ✓ Reviewed annually or sooner if legislation, Tusla guidance or incidents require
- ✓ Incorporates audit findings, child/family feedback and regulatory updates
- ✓ Considers trends in safeguarding concerns and allegations
- ✓ Reviewed policy approved by Registered Provider and communicated to all staff with sign-off sheet
- ✓ Superseded versions archived per record management procedures